SLOs & Error Budgets

Agree how reliable a service needs to be, measure it as users feel it, and use the error budget to balance new work with reliability.

Engineering Practices · Inspired by Site Reliability Engineering (Beyer, Jones, Petoff, Murphy, Google) · Reliability Is a Feature

SERVICE _____

DATE _____

1 Users & Journeys

WHO DEPENDS ON THIS, AND FOR WHAT?

JOURNEY	WHO	WHAT GOOD FEELS LIKE

e.g. Check out a basket · shoppers · page loads fast, payment works

2 Service Level Indicators

MEASURE WHAT USERS FEEL

INDICATOR	GOOD EVENTS / VALID EVENTS	SOURCE

e.g. Latency: requests under 300 ms / all requests

3 Objectives (SLOs)

TARGET · WINDOW · WHY

SLO	TARGET	WINDOW	WHY THIS LEVEL

e.g. 99.5% of checkouts succeed, over 30 days

4 Error Budget

100% MINUS THE SLO = ROOM TO TAKE RISKS

SLO target: _____

Budget (100% – target): _____

Allowed bad events or minutes: _____

Used so far: _____

Remaining: _____

SHADE THE BUDGET USED THIS WINDOW

0% 25% 50% 75% 100%

DOWNTIME ALLOWED IN 30 DAYS

99%	7 h 12 min
99.5%	3 h 36 min
99.9%	43 min
99.95%	22 min
99.99%	4 min

Each extra nine costs far more effort. Choose the lowest target that keeps users happy, not the highest you can.

5 Error Budget Policy

AGREED BEFORE IT'S NEEDED

Healthy
More than half left

Ship as normal. Spare budget can pay for experiments and planned risk.

Our rule: _____

Running low
Less than a quarter left

Slow risky changes, and put reliability work at the top.

Our rule: _____

Spent
None left

Pause risky releases except fixes, until the budget recovers.

Our rule: _____

6 Budget Review

PRODUCT AND ENGINEERING, TOGETHER

How often we review: _____

Who decides: _____

Where the dashboard lives: _____

Alert us when the budget burns faster than: _____

7 Reliability Backlog

WORK THAT PROTECTS THE BUDGET

ACTION	OWNER	BY WHEN

"Which users would notice first if this service got worse?"

"What would we stop doing if the budget ran out tomorrow?"

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